

## **HR & Company Policies**

### **1. Code of Conduct**

**Policy ID:** HR-001 **Effective Date:** January 1, 2025 **Owner:** Chief Human Resources Officer

#### **1.1 Purpose**

This Code of Conduct establishes the standards of professional behavior expected of all employees, contractors, and third-party representatives acting on behalf of Meridian Corporation. Violations may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.

#### **1.2 Workplace Behavior**

All employees are expected to treat colleagues, clients, and vendors with respect and professionalism. Harassment, discrimination, or intimidation based on race, gender, religion, national origin, disability, age, or sexual orientation is strictly prohibited.

#### **1.3 Conflicts of Interest**

Employees must disclose any personal, financial, or familial relationship that could create a real or perceived conflict of interest. Disclosures must be submitted to the Compliance department using Form COI-12 within 30 days of the conflict arising.

#### **1.4 Confidentiality**

Employees may not share proprietary information, trade secrets, client data, or internal financial data with unauthorized parties, including after separation from employment. NDAs are binding for 3 years post-employment.

#### **1.5 Reporting Violations**

Employees may report suspected violations via the anonymous Ethics Hotline (1-800-555-0199) or by emailing [ethics@meridian-corp.com](mailto:ethics@meridian-corp.com). Retaliation against whistleblowers is a terminable offense.

### **2. Leave & Attendance Policy**

**Policy ID:** HR-004 **Effective Date:** March 1, 2025 **Owner:** HR Business Partners

#### **2.1 Annual Leave**

Full-time employees accrue 1.5 days of paid annual leave per month, capped at 30 days per calendar year. Unused leave up to 10 days may be carried forward. Leave requests must be submitted via the HR portal at least 5 business days in advance.

## **2.2 Sick Leave**

Employees are entitled to 12 days of paid sick leave annually. Sick leave does not carry forward. For absences exceeding 3 consecutive days, a medical certificate from a licensed physician is required.

## **2.3 Parental Leave**

Primary caregivers are entitled to 16 weeks of fully paid parental leave. Secondary caregivers are entitled to 4 weeks. Leave must commence within 6 months of birth or legal adoption. Employees must notify HR at least 8 weeks before the expected leave start date.

## **2.4 Unpaid Leave**

Unpaid leave of up to 90 days may be approved at management discretion for personal, educational, or medical reasons not covered by standard entitlements. Benefits continue during the first 30 days; thereafter, employees may opt into continuation coverage at their own expense.

## **2.5 Attendance Standards**

Employees with unplanned absences exceeding 8 days in a rolling 12-month period will be placed on an attendance improvement plan. Three consecutive no-call/no-show incidents constitute job abandonment.

# **3. Performance Management Policy**

**Policy ID:** HR-007 **Effective Date:** January 1, 2025 **Owner:** Talent Management Division

## **3.1 Review Cycle**

All employees undergo a formal performance review twice annually — mid-year (June) and year-end (December). New hires complete a 90-day probationary review in addition to the standard cycle.

## **3.2 Rating Scale**

Performance is rated on a 5-point scale:

- **5 – Exceptional:** Consistently exceeds all objectives; demonstrates leadership

- **4 – Exceeds Expectations:** Regularly surpasses key deliverables
- **3 – Meets Expectations:** Fulfills role requirements reliably
- **2 – Needs Improvement:** Falls short in one or more core areas
- **1 – Unsatisfactory:** Fails to meet minimum role requirements

### **3.3 Performance Improvement Plans (PIPs)**

Employees rated 1 or 2 at year-end review will be placed on a 60-day PIP with clearly defined, measurable objectives. Failure to meet PIP objectives may result in role reassignment or termination.

### **3.4 Promotion Criteria**

Employees must hold a rating of 4 or above for two consecutive review cycles to be eligible for promotion consideration. All promotions require VP-level approval and a formal compensation adjustment.

## **4. Remote Work Policy**

**Policy ID:** HR-012 **Effective Date:** June 1, 2025 **Owner:** HR Operations

### **4.1 Eligibility**

Remote work is available to employees in roles classified as "remote-eligible" by their department head. Client-facing, lab, and manufacturing roles are generally not eligible.

### **4.2 Hybrid Minimum**

All remote-eligible employees are required to be present in-office a minimum of 2 days per week, typically Tuesday and Thursday, unless an alternate schedule is approved by their direct manager.

### **4.3 Equipment & Security**

The company provides a standard equipment package (laptop, headset, monitor) for remote employees. Employees must use company-issued devices for all work activities. Use of personal devices to access corporate systems is prohibited without prior IT approval and MDM enrollment.

### **4.4 Home Office Stipend**

Employees approved for full-time remote work receive a one-time home office setup stipend of \$800 and a monthly internet reimbursement of \$50, payable through the expense system with receipts.

## **5. Disciplinary Policy**

**Policy ID:** HR-015 **Effective Date:** January 1, 2025 **Owner:** Employee Relations

### **5.1 Progressive Discipline**

Meridian follows a progressive discipline framework:

1. **Verbal Warning** — Documented by manager; copy filed in employee record
2. **Written Warning** — Issued by HR; employee must acknowledge in writing
3. **Final Written Warning** — Includes a 30-day corrective action period
4. **Termination** — Requires CHRO and Legal approval

### **5.2 Gross Misconduct**

Certain offenses bypass progressive discipline and result in immediate termination. These include: theft, fraud, physical violence, sexual harassment, data breach (intentional), and reporting to work under the influence of controlled substances.

### **5.3 Appeals Process**

Employees may appeal disciplinary decisions within 10 business days by submitting a written appeal to the Employee Relations team. An independent review panel convenes within 20 business days.